



## Identifying when to use a semicolon

Adverbs such as *however*, *accordingly*, *besides*, and *therefore* can also be used as conjunctions to join two main clauses. Unlike coordinating conjunctions and subordinators, these adverbs must be preceded by a semicolon and followed by a comma.

two main clauses  
She was confident. She hadn't cut the hedge before.

coordinating conjunction separating two main clauses  
She was confident, **but** she hadn't cut the hedge before.

This adverb is being used as a conjunction, so it must be preceded by a semicolon and followed by a comma.  
She was confident; **however**, she hadn't cut the hedge before.

## Coordinating multiple subjects

When a coordinating conjunction is used to link two main clauses with different subjects, a comma should be placed before the conjunction. This helps to show where one main clause ends and another begins.

first main clause first subject  
**Flora tried to water her roses and sunflowers, but the hose burst.**  
A comma and coordinating conjunction separate the two main clauses.  
second subject second main clause

sunflowers, **but** the hose burst.  
tree **because** they were too tall.

## Subordinators

Subordinators or subordinating conjunctions are used to connect words, phrases, and clauses of unequal importance. A subordinate clause adds information to a main clause, explaining why, where, or when something is happening. Subordinate clauses start with subordinators like *before*, *if*, *because*, *although*, and *while*, and can be placed at the beginning or end of a sentence.

main clause  
**She cut both the hedge and the tree because they were too tall.**  
subordinator  
The subordinate clause explains why Flora cut the hedge.  
subordinator  
A subordinate clause can also go at the start of a sentence.  
**Before she started, she put on some gloves.**  
A comma is needed to separate the two clauses when the subordinator is at the start of a sentence.  
main clause